FREE GUIDE

The Reset *Between Points*

A 15-second mental reset for the moment after a mistake. Breathe, release, and come back to one clear cue before the next point begins.

Breathe
Seconds 0–5

Release
Seconds 5–10

Refocus
Seconds 10–15

For competitive fencers, athletes in any sport, and the coaches and parents who stand beside them. Includes a coach's cueing guide, a parent's guide, and a printable practice tracker.

BEFORE WE BEGIN

A note from me

Every athlete makes mistakes. That part is not optional. What happens in the few seconds after a mistake is where you do have a choice, and that is what this guide is about.

As a fencing coach, the moment I watch most closely is not the touch itself. It is the walk back to the en-garde line afterwards. In those few steps you can see whether a fencer is still in the bout, or whether they are still standing in the last touch, replaying it, arguing with it, and carrying it into the next one.

Most of us were never taught what to do in that gap. We were told to "forget it" or "focus", which is good advice that comes without instructions. This guide gives you the instructions: a short, simple routine you can do in about fifteen seconds, in any sport, at any level.

It is deliberately small. It will not make mistakes disappear, and it is not a pep talk. It is a habit you build in training, so that when the pressure is real, your body already knows the way back.

How to use this guide

- **Athletes:** read pages 3 to 7, then print the tracker on page 10 and use it for two weeks.
- **Coaches:** read the reset itself, then page 8 on cueing it in lessons.
- **Parents:** read pages 3 and 4, then page 9 on what to say after a mistake or a loss.

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01 · THE PROBLEM

The post-error spiral

One mistake rarely loses a bout. The spiral that follows it often does.

Here is how it tends to unfold. You will probably recognise some of it. I see it from the side of the piste more often than any technical error.

1. The mistake. You fall short on an attack, or get caught by a counter you saw coming.

2. The replay. Your mind rewinds the action again and again. "Why did I do that?"

3. The judgement. The replay turns into a verdict on you: "I always do this." "I'm not good enough for this level."

4. The body follows. Shoulders rise, breathing gets high and short, grip tightens, footwork stiffens.

5. The next point starts too soon. You are physically on the line, but mentally you are still one point behind.

6. Mistake number two. Often a rushed, "make up for it" action, and the cycle tightens.

Notice that the second mistake is often not caused by a lack of skill. It is caused by unfinished business from the first. The point has ended on the scoreboard, but not in your head.

What the spiral sounds like in other sports

- **Tennis:** a double fault, then a rushed second serve on the next point.
- **Basketball:** a missed free throw, then forcing a shot on the next possession.
- **Football:** a missed chance, then hiding from the ball for the next ten minutes.
- **Golf:** a poor tee shot, then an aggressive recovery that compounds the damage.

> The goal is not to feel nothing after a mistake. Frustration is normal and even useful: it tells you that you care. The goal is to **close the point**, so the next one gets your full attention. That is the job of the reset.

02 · THE METHOD

The reset at a glance

Three steps. About fifteen seconds. Done the same way every time, until it becomes yours.

1
Breathe
SECONDS 0–5

One slow breath in through the nose, and a longer breath out. This is the signal to your body that the point is over.

2
Release
SECONDS 5–10

A small physical action and a short word that let the last point go. You acknowledge it, then you put it down.

3
Refocus
SECONDS 10–15

Choose one simple cue for the next point. One, not five. Then step back into position with that cue in mind.

Why it is built this way

Body first, then mind. After a mistake, it is hard to think your way calm. It is much easier to breathe your way there first, and then think clearly.

Let go before you aim. If you try to refocus while still holding the last point, the two compete for your attention. The release step creates space for the cue.

One cue, because pressure shrinks attention. Under stress, you will not remember a list. You can remember one word.

Where the fifteen seconds come from

Almost every sport has a natural pause between points: the walk back to the en-garde line in fencing, the towel or the baseline in tennis, the free-throw line in basketball, the walk to the ball in golf, the restart in football. The reset is designed to fit inside that pause. If your pause is shorter, compress it. If it is longer, slow each step down. The order stays the same.

"The point is over when you decide it is over. The reset is how you decide."

This routine is a training tool for focus and composure. It is not medical or clinical advice. If an athlete's distress after mistakes feels persistent or overwhelming, please speak with a qualified professional.

Breathe, then release

STEP 1 Breathe

As soon as the point ends, take **one** deliberate breath:

- In through the nose, slowly, letting the belly move rather than the shoulders.
- Out through the mouth, a little longer than the in-breath, as if you are fogging a mirror.
- Let the shoulders drop on the out-breath.

In fencing: do it as you turn and begin the walk back. Your mask is on, so nobody needs to see it. Let the out-breath happen as you lower the blade.

Common mistakes: breathing in too hard and fast (it feels like a gasp), or doing three or four breaths and losing the rhythm of the bout. One good breath is enough.

STEP 2 Release

Now let the last point go with a **gesture** and a **word**, done together.

Choose a gesture that is small, physical and the same every time:

- Open and close your non-weapon hand.
- Brush your thigh, as if brushing off dust.
- Adjust your glove or your mask strap.
- In other sports: fix your strings, wipe your hands on your shorts, re-tape a sock.

Choose a word that closes the point: "Next." "Gone." "Done." "Okay."

If you need to acknowledge the mistake, do it in one short, factual line first: "Too early." Then the release word. No essays, no verdicts.

The "bin" image

Some athletes like an image. Picture dropping the last point into a bin at the side of the piste as you pass it. You are allowed to look at it later, after the bout, when you review. Right now it stays in the bin.

Make it yours. The specific gesture and word matter less than doing them the same way every time. Repetition is what turns them into a switch. Pick yours now and write them on the tracker on page 10.

04 · STEP THREE

Refocus on one cue

The final five seconds point your attention forward, at something you can actually do on the next point.

What makes a good cue

- **Short:** one to three words.
- **About action, not outcome:** "Long arm", not "Win this touch".
- **Positive:** what to do, not what to avoid. "Patient feet" works better than "Don't rush".
- **Within your control** on the very next point.

Example cues

Sport	After this kind of mistake...	...a possible cue
Fencing	Rushed an attack from too far	"Patient feet"
Fencing	Got hit by a counter-attack	"Blade first"
Fencing	Froze and was pushed off the end	"Own the distance"
Tennis	Double fault	"Smooth toss"
Basketball	Missed free throw	"Soft wrist"
Football	Lost the ball in midfield	"Scan first"
Golf	Poor tee shot	"Pick the target"
Volleyball	Serve into the net	"Tall contact"

These are examples, not prescriptions. The best cue is one you and your coach agree on and have used in training.

Two ways to choose your cue

The correction cue. A simple word that addresses what just went wrong, such as "patient feet" after rushing. Use it when you know exactly what happened.

The anchor cue. One "home" cue you use whenever you are unsure, such as "loose and sharp". Use it when you do not know what went wrong, or when the error was simply the opponent's good touch.

Say the cue once, quietly, as you settle into your ready position. Then trust it and let the point happen.

05 · TRAINING

How to practise it in training

A reset you only try at competitions is a hope. A reset you have repeated hundreds of times in training is a skill.

Stage	What to do	Move on when...
1. Rehearse it cold Days 1–3	At home or before training, run the three steps slowly ten times. Choose your gesture, word and anchor cue. Time a few to feel the fifteen seconds.	You can do it without thinking about the order.
2. Attach it to drills Days 4–7	In footwork or technical drills, reset after every miss or poor rep. Keep it quick and quiet. Don't skip it on "small" errors.	It starts to happen automatically after a miss.
3. Use it in bouts Week 2	In sparring or practice games, reset after every point you lose, and after any point you win but did not like.	You notice the spiral less often.
4. Add pressure Week 3 onward	Play "pressure points": start bouts at a close score, or play short games where one error costs you. Reset every single time.	It holds when the score matters.

Three habits that help

- **Reset after good points too, now and then.** It keeps the routine neutral, rather than a sign that something went wrong.
- **Review later, not now.** Keep a short note after training on what you reset from. Analysis belongs after the session, not between points.
- **Track it.** Use the tracker on page 10. Seeing your consistency on paper is surprisingly motivating.

Going deeper

The reset is one small piece of a bigger picture. In my course, **The Mental Performance Protocol**, I go further into building composure, confidence and focus as trainable skills, across training and competition. If this guide is useful, you can read more at thementalsport.com/course. No pressure: the reset works on its own.

06 · FOR COACHES

Cueing the reset in lessons

Athletes adopt what their coach makes normal. If the reset lives in your lessons, it will show up in their bouts.

Build it into the lesson structure

- **Teach the three steps once, clearly,** and let each athlete choose their own gesture, word and anchor cue. Ownership matters.
- **Leave a gap after errors.** In an individual lesson, after a missed action, pause and let the athlete reset before you give the next feed. Do not fill the gap with correction straight away.
- **Then give one cue, not three.** Your technical feedback can become their refocus cue: "Again. Blade first." Keep it to one thing.
- **Reward the reset, not just the touch.** "Good reset there" is worth saying, especially when the next action still misses.

Short coaching cues that work

In the moment	Purpose
"Breathe, then go."	Prompts step one without a lecture.
"Bin it."	Prompts the release, using a shared image.
"What's your cue?"	Puts the athlete in charge of step three.
"Reset first."	A gentle reminder when they rush back onto the line.

During competition

Between touches and at breaks, your words carry extra weight. Keep them calm, few and forward-looking. If the athlete is in the spiral, start with the breath before any tactical point: one breath together, then one cue. Tactics land better on a calm mind.

> **Model it yourself.** Athletes notice how you react to their mistakes. A steady voice and a quick move to the next action teach the reset as much as any explanation.

07 · FOR PARENTS

What to say after a mistake or a loss

Your support matters enormously. Often the most helpful thing is simpler, and quieter, than we expect.

During the event

Between points and between bouts, your child is practising their own reset. Help them by keeping your reactions steady. A calm face in the stands is a gift. Leave the coaching to the coach, and keep your messages short and warm.

Instead of...	Try...
"Why did you keep attacking like that?"	"I loved watching you compete today."
"You should have beaten her."	"That was a tough bout. How are you feeling?"
"Don't be upset, it's only a game."	"It's okay to be disappointed. It shows you care."
"Next time, just focus."	"Did you get to use your reset today?"
A detailed replay in the car	Quiet, a snack, and "I'm here whenever you want to talk about it."

After a loss: a simple order

1. Comfort first. Food, water, a hug if they want one. Bodies settle before minds do.

2. Listen second. Let them talk when they are ready. Often that is hours later, not minutes.

3. Learn last, and lightly. If they want to reflect, ask open questions: "What went well?" "What would you like to try next time?" Let their coach handle the technical side.

> **The quiet message underneath everything:** your love and pride do not depend on the result. When children feel that clearly, mistakes become something they can learn from, rather than something they have to fear.

08 · PRINTABLE

The Reset Between Points: practice tracker

Print this page. Fill in one row per session for two weeks. Rate each step 1 (hard) to 3 (smooth). Analysis stays here, after training, not between points.

My breath	My release gesture + word	My anchor cue

Date	Session (drill / bout / comp)	Resets used	Breathe 1–3	Release 1–3	Refocus 1–3	Cue I used most	One note for next time
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		
			1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3		

After two weeks: where does the reset work best for me?	Where is it still hard, and what will I try?

Breathe (0–5 s) · Release (5–10 s) · Refocus on one cue (10–15 s)

09 · WHERE TO GO FROM HERE

Close the point. Open the next one.

If you take only one thing from this guide, let it be this: a mistake ends when the point ends, as long as you give yourself a way to end it.

Start small. Choose your breath, your gesture, your word and your cue. Practise them in drills this week, track them for two weeks, and notice what changes. Be patient with yourself. Some days the reset will feel natural, some days clumsy. Both are part of learning it.

And if you are a coach or a parent, remember that you are part of the reset too. The calm you bring is something the athlete borrows until they can find it on their own.

IF YOU WANT TO GO FURTHER

The Mental Performance Protocol

The reset is one tool. My online course, The Mental Performance Protocol, brings together the mental-performance skills I teach, so you can build composure, focus and confidence with the same structure you bring to your physical training. It is designed for competitive athletes, and useful for the coaches and parents who support them.

Course price: $297 · Details and enrolment at
thementalsport.com/course

About Giannis Notaras

I am a fencing coach in Athens, Greece, where I coach at A.O. Apollon Vrilission, and I am one of the coaches named for athletes in the Hellenic Fencing Federation's pre-Olympic sabre squad for Los Angeles 2028. Alongside my work on the piste, I founded The Mental Sport and have written a series of books on the mental side of competition. I believe composure, focus and confidence can be trained as deliberately as footwork, and this guide is a good place to start.

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